

Working Mother Time Poverty Exhaustion — Action Checklist

PRINT THIS PAGE AND KEEP IT SOMEWHERE VISIBLE

AUDIT YOUR ACTUAL TIME

- ☐ **Track every hour for one week in three columns — Activity, Duration, and Who Benefited — so you can see where your time is actually going instead of where you assume it's going.:** Track every hour for one week in three columns — Activity, Duration, and Who Benefited — so you can see where your time is actually going instead of where you assume it's going.
- ☐ **Sort your tracked activities by duration to find your top 5 time consumers, which typically represent 60-70% of your weekly hours.:** Sort your tracked activities by duration to find your top 5 time consumers, which typically represent 60-70% of your weekly hours.
- ☐ **Apply the Release Test to your top 5 activities by asking:** Is this legally required, would anyone notice if I stopped, and did I choose this or absorb it?
- ☐ **Identify which tasks you absorbed without choosing them versus which activities you actively selected, so you know what was never yours to begin with.:** Identify which tasks you absorbed without choosing them versus which activities you actively selected, so you know what was never yours to begin with.

RELEASE UNNECESSARY OBLIGATIONS

- ☐ **Protect four non-negotiable windows:** the first 20 minutes after waking, the last 30 minutes before bed, one meaningful daily conversation, and attendance at significant events only.
- ☐ **Replace at least three perfectionist standards with simpler alternatives such as store-bought items instead of homemade, financial contributions instead of volunteering, and functional spaces instead of pristine ones.:** Replace at least three perfectionist standards with simpler alternatives such as store-bought items instead of homemade, financial contributions instead of volunteering, and functional spaces instead of pristine ones.
- ☐ **Shift your focus from performing perfectly to being emotionally present and consistent, which is what your child actually needs from you.:** Shift your focus from performing perfectly to being emotionally present and consistent, which is what your child actually needs from you.

- **Use a short, firm response when others comment on your choices, saying "We've let some things go this season. It's fine" with no further explanation needed.:** Use a short, firm response when others comment on your choices, saying "We've let some things go this season. It's fine" with no further explanation needed.

SET BOUNDARIES WITH OTHERS

- **Have a direct conversation with your partner about who handles which tasks and propose specific changes based on your actual tracked hours, not assumptions.:** Have a direct conversation with your partner about who handles which tasks and propose specific changes based on your actual tracked hours, not assumptions.
- **Give yourself permission to release household standards that nobody else in your family maintains, because choosing to let things go is not failure.:** Give yourself permission to release household standards that nobody else in your family maintains, because choosing to let things go is not failure.
- **Set a personal threshold for what counts as a "significant event" worth attending rather than trying to be present for every school and social obligation.:** Set a personal threshold for what counts as a "significant event" worth attending rather than trying to be present for every school and social obligation.
- **Accept that releasing standards is a structural choice, not a personal shortcoming, because the math of your week makes perfection impossible regardless of effort.:** Accept that releasing standards is a structural choice, not a personal shortcoming, because the math of your week makes perfection impossible regardless of effort.